

Why Choose Specification 44 over NatHERS?

This document explains why someone might choose to use Specification 44 under the National Construction Code (NCC) as an alternative to the NatHERS (Nationwide House Energy Rating Scheme) pathway for demonstrating residential energy efficiency compliance.

1. Greater Design Flexibility

Specification 44 allows more freedom in design choices, enabling creative building shapes, orientations, and use of non-standard materials that might not rate well under NatHERS.

2. Transparent and Quantifiable Targets

Unlike NatHERS, which outputs a star rating, Spec 44 provides explicit thermal load targets (in MJ/m²/year), making performance goals easier to track and validate.

3. Alternative for Non-Compliant NatHERS Designs

If a design cannot achieve the required 7-star rating, it may still comply using Specification 44 if it meets the defined heating and cooling load limits.

4. Aligns Better with Performance-First Approaches

Specification 44 focuses on actual energy performance rather than star-based proxies, which aligns better with carbon accounting, Net Zero goals, and lifecycle analysis.

5. Supports Innovation and Non-Standard Construction

Innovative or alternative construction types that don't model well in NatHERS (e.g., earth buildings, SIPs) may be easier to justify through Specification 44.

6. Compliance Without Full NatHERS Certification

Projects with internal modeling capabilities may avoid full third-party NatHERS certification by using Specification 44, saving time and cost.

■ ■ When Not to Use Specification 44

Specification 44 requires more complex modeling and documentation. For standard residential homes, NatHERS is often quicker and more cost-effective. Building certifiers may also be more familiar with the NatHERS pathway.

■ Summary: Why Choose Specification 44?

- Flexibility in design – Accommodates unique layouts and orientations.
- Clear performance benchmarks – Uses MJ/m²/year load targets.
- Alternative to failed NatHERS rating – A second compliance pathway.
- More accurate modeling – Supports advanced software tools.
- Budget/time advantages – Possible to avoid full certification.
- Better for innovation – Ideal for passive, net zero, or modular builds.